

Electricity & Magnetism

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1 Electric Charges and Fields

1.1 Electric Charge and Electric Force

Electric Charge

- **Electric charge** (q or Q) is a fundamental property of matter.
- Electric charge is measured in the SI derived unit *Coulombs* (C).
 - Coulombs are equal to *ampere seconds*, being the amount of charge transferred in a 1 A current in one second ($C = A \cdot s$).
- Electric charge comes from **charge carriers**: protons (p^+) and electrons (e^-)
 - The magnitude of charge of both protons and electrons are equal to the *elementary charge*:

$$\text{Elementary Charge} = e = 1.6 \cdot 10^{-19} \text{ C}$$

$$|q_{\text{proton}}| = |q_{\text{electron}}| = e.$$

- Protons p^+ carry a positive charge of $+e$, and electrons e^- carry a negative charge of $-e$.
- Electric charge is a **quantized scalar**.
 - **Quantized:** electric charge can only be integer multiples of the elementary charge e .
In other words, something can only have a charge of $q = ke$, where $k \in \mathbb{Z}$ and e is the elementary charge.
 - **Scalar:** charge does not have direction, but it can be either positive or negative.

Example:

An object consists of 4 protons and 6 electrons. What is its charge in Coulombs?

$$\begin{aligned} Q &= (n_{\text{protons}} - n_{\text{electrons}})e = (4 - 6)e = -2e = -2(1.60 \cdot 10^{-19} \text{ C}) \\ &= -3.20 \cdot 10^{-19} \text{ C}. \end{aligned}$$

Law of Charges

Two charges of opposing signs *attract*, and two charges of the same sign *repel*.

- A **point charge** refers to an object or system which has charge, but has negligible physical size. Point charges are easy to deal with because the direction from the charge to any object solely depends on the position of the object.

Atomic Constants

- Mass of a Proton and Neutron¹: $m_p \approx m_n \approx 1.67 \cdot 10^{-27}$ kg
- Mass of an Electron: $m_e \approx 9.11 \cdot 10^{-31}$ kg
- Elementary Charge: $e \approx 1.60 \cdot 10^{-19}$ C

Coulomb's Law

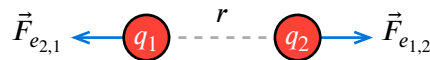
Coulomb's Law

Let q_1 and q_2 be the charges of two point charges a distance r between their centers of charge. Then, the *electrostatic force* $\vec{F}_e$ exerted by q_2 on q_1 is:

$$\text{Electrostatic Force} = \vec{F}_e = k_e \frac{q_1 q_2}{r^2} \hat{r}$$

where:

- k_e is **Coulomb's constant**, defined as $k_e = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \approx 8.99 \cdot 10^9 \text{ N m}^2 \text{ C}^{-2}$
 - ϵ_0 is the **permittivity of free space**, which is a constant which we will define later.
- $\hat{r}$ is the unit vector directed *away* from the location of q_1 .
 - in other words, if q_1 and q_2 are the same sign, the force will repel the charges *away* from each other.



- By Newton's Third Law, $\vec{F}_{e1,2} = -\vec{F}_{e2,1}$. Two charges will always exert a pair of electrostatic forces on each other.
- Notice that Coulomb's Law mirrors the Universal Law of Gravitation, $\vec{F}_G = G \frac{m_1 m_2}{r^2} \hat{r}$.
 - $G \approx 6.67 \cdot 10^{-11} \text{ N m}^2 \text{ kg}^{-2}$, the gravitational constant, is *much* smaller than k_e . This means that for large scale objects which are *charged*, gravitational force is negligible compared to the electrostatic force.

However, it is often the case that large objects *aren't* charged (they are neutral since), which is why we still see the effects of gravitational force.

- In the case of $\vec{F}_G$, $\hat{r}$ points *towards* the other object rather than *away*. Gravity is always an attractive force. In contrast, electrostatic force can be either attractive or repulsive.

¹ $m_p \neq m_n$, but their difference is negligible.

Example: Relative Electrostatic Force

Two charges of magnitude q placed a distance d from each other exhibit a repulsive force of magnitude F . What is the electrostatic force of two charges of magnitude $3q$ placed a distance $2d$ from each other?

By Coulomb's Law, the initial force is:

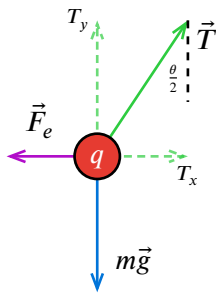
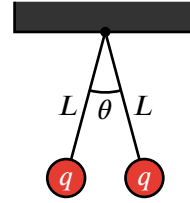
$$F = k_e \frac{q^2}{d^2}.$$

For the new charges, the force is:

$$F_{\text{new}} = k_e \frac{(3q)^2}{(2d)^2} = k_e \frac{9q^2}{4d^2} = \frac{9}{4}F.$$

Example: Charged Bobs on a Pendulum

Two identically charged balls of mass m are in static equilibrium while hanging from the ceiling on strings of length L . The total angle between them is θ ($0^\circ \leq \theta < 180^\circ$). Find the charge q on each ball.



FBD for the left-hanging ball

For vertical forces to balance, set $T_y = mg$:

$$T_y = T \cos\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) = mg \implies T = \frac{mg}{\cos\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)}.$$

For horizontal forces to balance, set $T_x = F_e$, where F_e is the magnitude of electrostatic repulsion:

$$T_x = T \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) = F_e = k_e \frac{q^2}{r^2}.$$

r is the distance between the two balls. Since each ball is a distance $L \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)$ from the center, $r = 2L \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)$. Thus:

$$T \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) = k_e \frac{q^2}{\left(2L \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)\right)^2} = k_e \frac{q^2}{4L^2 \sin^2\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)}.$$

Replace the expression for tension T from earlier and substitute $k_e = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0}$:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{mg}{\cos\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)} \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) &= k_e \frac{q^2}{4L^2 \sin^2\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)} \\ mg \tan\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) &= \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q^2}{4L^2 \sin^2\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)}. \end{aligned}$$

Solving for q :

$$\begin{aligned} q^2 &= 16L^2 \sin^2\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) \pi \epsilon_0 mg \tan\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) \\ q &= 4L \sin\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right) \sqrt{\pi \epsilon_0 mg \tan\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)}. \end{aligned}$$

Charge Distributions

Law of Superposition for Coulomb's Law (Discrete)

Let $q_1, q_2, \dots, q_n$ be a discrete set of charges in space. A particle of charge Q will have its electrostatic force be the vector sum of all individual electrostatic forces:

$$\vec{F}_e = \sum_i \vec{F}_{e_i, Q} = \sum_i k_e \frac{q_i Q}{r^2} \hat{r}.$$

In other words, the net electrostatic force is the sum of all individual electrostatic forces.

We can generalize this law to continuous charge distributions. For every small change in charge along a charged object dq , the change in electrostatic force $d\vec{F}_e$ is:

$$d\vec{F}_e = k_e \frac{Q dq}{r^2} \hat{r}.$$

Thus, by the law of superposition:

Law of Superposition for Coulomb's Law (Continuous)

Let Q be a point charge and let an object have a continuous charge distribution $\mathcal{D}$. Then, the net electrostatic force $\vec{F}_e$ must be:

$$\vec{F}_e = k_e \int_{\mathcal{D}} \frac{Q}{r^2} \hat{r} dq.$$

1.2 Conservation of Electric Charge

Conservation of Charge

The Law of Conservation of Charge

For isolated systems, net charge is *conserved*:

$$\Sigma Q_i = \Sigma Q_f.$$

This law holds because in an isolated system, charge carriers (i.e. electrons) cannot enter or leave the system.

- Charge cannot be created or destroyed, only *transferred* between objects or particles.
- The *charge distribution* of an isolated system may change, but the *net charge* of the system remains constant.

Insulators and Conductors

- It is difficult to redistribute charges in an **insulator**. Electrons are bound tightly to the atomic nuclei, and cannot easily move. (Electrons are *localized*).
 - We say that the electrons *resist* movement.
 - The degree to which the electrons of a material resist movement is called *resistivity*.
- It is easy to redistribute charges in a **conductor**. Electrons can freely move (they are *delocalized*).
 - The degree to which the electrons of a material are able to move is called *conductivity*. It is the inverse of resistivity (conductivity = $\frac{1}{\text{resistivity}}$).
- **Semiconductors** have properties resembling both conductors and insulators. Electrons are somewhat bound to the atomic nuclei, and conductivity *varies* based on the composition of materials.

Methods of Charging

- An object can have a change in charge when they are introduced into a new system, allowing the charge of the system to distribute into the object.
- When a previously neutral object obtains charge, we say that the object has been *charged*.

Charging by Friction

- When two *insulating* objects are rubbed together, electrons can be transferred from one object to another. This process is called *charging by friction*.
- The object that *gains* electrons becomes *negatively charged*, and the object that *loses* electrons becomes *positively charged*.

Charging by Conduction (Contact)

- When an object touches a *conductor*, charge can be directly transferred through physical contact. The total charge of the object-conductor system is conserved.
- The distribution of charges between the individual objects depend *only* on their **initial charges** and their **sizes (charge capacities)**.
- Two *identical* objects of this manner will evenly distribute charge.
ex: sphere *A* (+4 μC) and sphere *B* (0 μC) make contact with each other.
If spheres *A* and *B* are identical in size, then the final charge on each is +2 μC.
 - To generalize, the final charge of each object after the *conduction* of *n* identical objects of initial charges $q_1, q_2, \dots, q_n$ is simply the average charge:

$$q_{\text{individual object after conduction}} = \frac{q_1 + q_2 + \dots + q_n}{n}.$$

Charging by Induction (Contactless)

- A nearby conductor may *induce* a redistribution of charge in an object. We call this process **induction** (or **polarization**).
 - It is very difficult to induce charge in an insulator, since electrons are not free to move.
- For example, bringing a negatively charged object to the left of a neutral conductor will induce a positive charge on the left side of the conductor and a negative charge on the right side of the conductor.
 - The net charge of the conductor remains *zero* since no charge was added or removed.
 - Taking away the charged object will cause the conductor to return to its original neutral state.

Example: Permanent Induction

Two neutral conducting spheres *A* and *B* are placed next to and are touching each other. A negatively charged rod is brought close to sphere *A* without touching it. After charge distribution reaches equilibrium, sphere *B* is separated from sphere *A*. Finally, the rod is removed. Describe the final charges on spheres *A* and *B*.

When the negatively charged rod is brought close to sphere *A*, it induces a positive charge on the left side of sphere *A* and a negative charge on the right side of sphere *A*.

Since spheres *A* and *B* are touching, the negative charge on the right side of sphere *A* repels electrons into sphere *B*, causing sphere *B* to become negatively charged.

After separation, sphere *A* retains a net positive charge since it lost electrons to sphere *B*.

Finally, when the rod is removed, **sphere *A* remains positively charged and sphere *B* remains negatively charged.**

Grounding

- A **ground** $\equiv$ is a relatively large conductor which can accept or supply an essentially infinite amount of charge.
 - Examples of grounds include the Earth, your body, or a large metal rod connected to the Earth.
- If electrons are able to freely move between a system and a ground, that system is **grounded**. A grounded system is allowed to reach equilibrium by transferring charge between the system and the ground.
 - If a system gains excess charge, that charge is transferred to the ground, allowing the system to return to a neutral state.

1.3 Electric Fields

Electric Field

Let $\vec{E}$ be the net **electric field** at any point P . Then, if a particle with charge q is placed at point P , then the net electrostatic force on the particle is:

$$\vec{F}_e = q\vec{E}.$$

By Coulomb's Law, the electric field at a point P induced by a point charge Q is:

$$\vec{E}_P = \frac{\vec{F}_e}{q} = k_e \frac{Q}{r^2} \hat{r}$$

where $\vec{r}$ is the distance vector from the position of Q to P .

- The **electric field** is the *electrostatic force per unit charge*.
 - Take a test charge q and place it a distance r from another charge Q . The charge Q induces an electrostatic force $\vec{F}_e$ on q and the electric field from Q is $\vec{F}_e/q$.
- The electric field is a vector function of position ($\vec{E}(x, y, z)$), making it a vector field (the electric field at every point is a vector).
- Electric field has units of *newtons per coulomb*, N / C
 - $\text{NC}^{-1} = \text{kg m s}^{-3} \text{A}^{-1}$ in SI base units.

Electric Field Lines

- Electric field lines generalize the electric field to general regions in space.
- Electric field lines will always move away from positive charges and into negative charges.
- Electric field lines will never cross, and by convention, lines drawn closer together indicate a greater magnitude of electric field.

1.4 Electric Fields of Charge Distributions

We can apply the law of superposition for electrostatic force to electric fields.

Discrete Charge Distributions

For discrete charge distributions (a finite set of point charges):

$$\vec{E} = \frac{\vec{F}_e}{Q} = \frac{\sum_i \vec{F}_{e_i,q}}{\sum_i q_i} = \sum_i \vec{E}_i.$$

In other words, the net electric field at a given position is the sum of the electric fields induced by all individual point charges.

Continuous Charge Distributions

Often times, we will deal with objects with non-negligible sizes where we must consider the **distribution of charge** throughout the object.

If we split an object into many small, negligibly-sized portions, we can consider each small portion its own point charge that contributes a small amount towards the total electric field.

Let dq be the additional charge of one of these negligibly-sized point charges. Then the additional electric field $d\vec{E}$ induced by this point charge is:

$$d\vec{E} = k_e \frac{dq}{r^2} \hat{r}.$$

The law of superposition allows us integrate both sides to obtain the net electric field:

$$\vec{E} = k_e \int \frac{1}{r^2} \hat{r} dq.$$

Note

The fact that $\hat{r}$ appears inside our integral can make calculations difficult, since the direction of each $\hat{r}$ can vary as we integrate through different positions along our object.

Luckily, at this level, we will only consider scenarios where $\hat{r}$ can be considered constant or where there is symmetry.

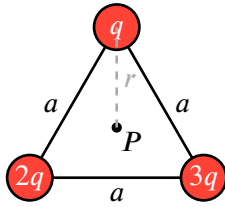
Often times, the charge differential dq is not directly given to us, but rather indirectly using a **charge density**. There are three charge densities:

- **Linear charge density** (λ), charge per unit length.
 - By definition, $\lambda = \frac{dq}{d\ell} \implies dq = \lambda d\ell$ where $d\ell$ is a small change in length.
 - SI units are *coulombs per meter*, C/m
- **Surface charge density** (σ), charge per unit surface area.
 - By definition, $\sigma = \frac{dq}{dA} \implies dq = \sigma dA$ where dA is a small change in surface area.

- ▶ SI units are *coulombs per square meter*, C/m^2
- **Volumetric charge density** (ρ), charge per unit volume.
 - ▶ By definition, $\rho = \frac{dq}{dV} \implies dq = \rho dV$ where dV is a small change in volume.
 - ▶ SI units are *coulombs per cubic meter*, C/m^3

If charge density is constant, the object is **uniformly charged**.

Example: Finding the Electric Field from Discrete Charges



Three point charges q , $2q$, and $3q$ are arranged in an equilateral triangle of side length a as shown. Find the electric field at the center of the triangle.

The distance r from a vertex to point P is $r = \frac{a}{\sqrt{3}}$. By Coulomb's law, the electric field magnitude due to a charge Q a distance r away is:

$$E = \frac{k_e Q}{r^2} = \frac{k_e Q}{\left(\frac{a}{\sqrt{3}}\right)^2} = \frac{3k_e Q}{a^2}.$$

where k_e is Coulomb's constant.

Thus, the magnitudes of electric field caused by each charge is:

$$E_1 = \frac{3k_e q}{a^2} \quad E_2 = \frac{6k_e q}{a^2} \quad E_3 = \frac{9k_e q}{a^2}.$$

By the law of superposition, $\vec{E}_P = \vec{E}_1 + \vec{E}_2 + \vec{E}_3$. However, we only have magnitudes, so we have to use trigonometry to break each magnitude into basis components.

Recall the electric field points *away* from the charge. For example, at point P , $\vec{E}_1$ would point downwards. This means $\vec{E}_1$ has no x -component and a negative y -component, so we derive $\vec{E}_1 = -E_1 \hat{j}$.

$\vec{E}_2$ makes a 30° angle with the positive x -axis, so $\vec{E}_2 = E_2(\hat{i} \cos 30^\circ + \hat{j} \sin 30^\circ)$. Similarly, $\vec{E}_3$ makes a 30° angle with the *negative* x -axis, so $\vec{E}_3 = E_3(-\hat{i} \cos 30^\circ + \hat{j} \sin 30^\circ)$.

Writing out the components:

$$\begin{aligned} \vec{E}_P &= (E_2 \cos 30^\circ - E_3 \cos 30^\circ) \hat{i} + (-E_1 + E_2 \sin 30^\circ + E_3 \sin 30^\circ) \hat{j} \\ &= (E_2 - E_3) \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \hat{i} + \left(-E_1 + \frac{E_2 + E_3}{2}\right) \hat{j} \\ &= \left(-\frac{3k_e q}{a^2}\right) \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \hat{i} + \left(-3 + \frac{6+9}{2}\right) \frac{k_e q}{a^2} \hat{j} = -\frac{3\sqrt{3}k_e q}{2a^2} \hat{i} + \frac{9k_e q}{2a^2} \hat{j}. \end{aligned}$$

Example: Electric Field from a Continuous Charge Distribution

Point P is a distance b directly to the left of a uniformly charged rod of length L with linear mass density λ . Derive an expression for the electric field at P .



First, since the rod is not a point charge, we are dealing with a *continuous charge distribution*:

$$\vec{E}_P = k_e \int_{x=0}^{x=L} \frac{1}{r^2} \hat{r} dq.$$

Let x be how far from the left side of the rod we are (so we integrate from 0 to L).

Realize that the direction of the electric field is always to the left. So, $\hat{r}$ must be constant and equal to $-\hat{i}$ (left-pointing unit vector). Also recognize that r is the distance from P to the left side plus x ($r = b + x$):

$$\vec{E}_P = k_e (-\hat{i}) \int_{x=0}^{x=L} \frac{1}{(b+x)^2} dq$$

Since we are given a linear mass density, use $dq = \lambda dx$:

$$\vec{E}_P = -k_e \hat{i} \int_0^L \frac{\lambda}{(b+x)^2} dx.$$

Since we know that the rod is *uniformly charged*, λ is constant, and we can now solve the integral and simplify:

$$\begin{aligned} \vec{E}_P &= -k_e \lambda \hat{i} \int_0^L \frac{1}{(b+x)^2} dx \\ &= -k_e \lambda \hat{i} \left[-\frac{1}{b+x} \right]_0^L \\ &= k_e \lambda \left(\frac{1}{b+L} - \frac{1}{b} \right) \hat{i} \\ &= -\frac{k_e \lambda L}{b(b+L)} \hat{i}. \end{aligned}$$

Since total charge $Q = \int_0^L dq = \int_0^L \lambda dx = \lambda L$, we can simplify in terms of Q :

$$\vec{E}_P = -\frac{k_e Q}{b(b+L)} \hat{i}$$

1.5 Electric Flux

Electric Flux

Let $\vec{E}$ be the electric field and $d\vec{A}$ be a vector element of area on a surface S . The **electric flux** Φ_E through the surface is:

$$\Phi_E = \iint_S \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A}$$

- $\vec{E}$ is the electric field at each point on the surface.
- $d\vec{A}$ is the vector with its magnitude being a small change in surface area, pointing perpendicularly outwards from the surface
($d\vec{A} = \hat{n} dA$ where $\hat{n}$ is the unit normal to S)

- **Electric flux** measures how much electric field “passes through” a given surface.
 - ▶ If $\vec{E}$ is perpendicular to $d\vec{A}$, the flux is maximized.
 - ▶ If $\vec{E}$ is parallel to $d\vec{A}$, the flux is zero.
 - ▶ The dot product ensures that only the component of the electric field perpendicular to the surface contributes to flux.
 - ▶ The surface here does not need to be an actual physical surface. It can be an imaginary surface which we use to analyze flux with, called a **Gaussian surface**.
- The symbol Φ_E or φ_E is used to refer to electric flux. It is a scalar quantity.
(or just Φ if no need to clarify which type of flux)
- The units for electric flux are $\frac{\text{N} \cdot \text{m}^2}{\text{C}}$ which is equivalent to the *volt-meter*, $\text{V} \cdot \text{m}$.
 - ▶ The latter unit is taken directly, *newton-meter squared per coulomb*, $\text{N m}^2 \text{C}^{-1}$.
 - ▶ A *volt* (V) is a measure of *electrical potential energy per unit charge* (which will be covered later), so volts have units of $\text{J/C} = \text{N m C}^{-1}$ (unit of energy divided by unit of charge).
 - ▶ Thus, a *volt-meter* is equivalent to a *newton-meter squared per coulomb*.
- If electric field is constant everywhere on the surface AND our surface is flat, then our equation simplifies:

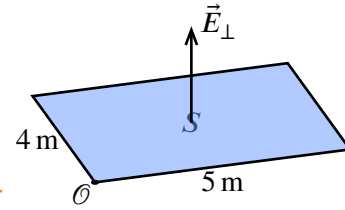
$$\Phi_E = \vec{E} \cdot \iint_S d\vec{A} = \vec{E} \cdot \vec{A}.$$

- By the definition of the dot product, the electric field for flat surfaces is:
 - ▶ $\Phi_E = EA \cos \theta$, if electric field is constant
 - ▶ $\Phi_E = \iint_S E \cos \theta dA$, if electric field is not constant

E is the magnitude of the electric field, A is surface area, and θ is the angle between the outwards-pointing normal vector to the surface and the electric field vector.

Example:

A non-uniform electric field $\vec{E} = \langle \alpha xy, \beta z^2, \gamma x + \delta y \rangle$ passes through a flat, rectangular surface S as shown in the diagram. What is the electric flux passing through S ? Assume x, y, z are specified in meters and $\alpha, \beta, \gamma, \delta$ are constants with appropriate units.



First, since we are only concerned about the component of the electric field that is perpendicular to S , we know that our effective electric field is $E = \gamma x + \delta y$ (i.e. we only consider the z -component of the electric field).

Now, this becomes a simple double integral:

$$\begin{aligned}\Phi_E &= \iint_S (\gamma x + \delta y) dA \\ &= \int_{y=0}^{4\text{ m}} \int_{x=0}^{5\text{ m}} (\gamma x + \delta y) dx dy \\ &= \int_0^{4\text{ m}} \left(\frac{\gamma}{2} x^2 + \delta y x \right) \Big|_{x=0}^{x=5\text{ m}} dy \\ &= \int_0^{4\text{ m}} \left(25\frac{\gamma}{2} + 5\delta y \right) dy \\ &= \left(25\frac{\gamma}{2} y + 5\frac{\delta}{2} y^2 \right) \Big|_0^{4\text{ m}} = 50\gamma + 40\delta.\end{aligned}$$

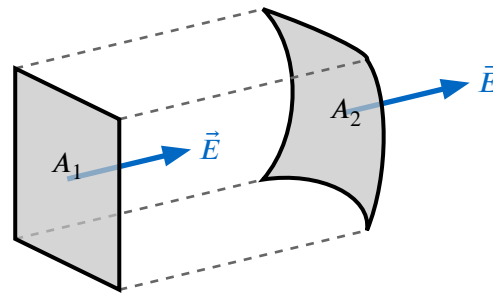
Projection Principle

The *projection principle* states that the electric flux through a curved surface is equal to the electric flux through the projection of that surface onto a plane perpendicular to the electric field.

If the direction of the electric field is not constant, we can break the curved surface into many small flat surfaces where the electric field is approximately constant, and apply the projection principle to each small surface.

This principle holds because for every small patch of area dA , the contribution to flux is:

$$d\Phi_E = \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} = E dA \cos \theta = E dA_{\perp}.$$



The electric flux through A_1 is equal to the electric flux through A_2 .

1.6 Gauss' Law

Assume an isolated point charge of magnitude q is situated at the center of a sphere of radius r . What is the total electric flux over the surface S of the sphere?

Using Coulomb's Law, we see that the magnitude of electric field $\vec{E}$ at any point on the sphere (i.e. a distance r from the charge) is:

$$|\vec{E}| = k_e \frac{q}{r^2}.$$

Also realize that:

- the magnitude electric field is constant for all points on the surface of the sphere
- the electric field $\vec{E}$ points in the same direction as $d\vec{A}$ for all points on the surface

Thus, the formula for electric flux simplifies:

$$\Phi_E = \iint_S \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} = \iint_S |\vec{E}| dA = E \iint_S dA = EA$$

Since A would simply be the surface area of the sphere $A = 4\pi r^2$:

$$\begin{aligned}\Phi_E = EA &= \left(k_e \frac{q}{r^2}\right)(4\pi r^2) \\ &= \left(\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0} \frac{q}{r^2}\right)4\pi r^2 \\ &= \frac{q}{\epsilon_0}\end{aligned}$$

It turns out that *all closed surfaces* which enclose a volume (“**Gaussian surfaces**”) can be projected as spheres, and thus this formula applies to all such surfaces. Formally:

Gauss' Law (Integral Form)

Let Φ_E be the *electric flux* through a **closed surface** S . Then:

$$\Phi_E = \oiint_S \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} = \frac{Q_{\text{enclosed}}}{\epsilon_0}$$

where:

- $\vec{E}$ is the electric field
- $d\vec{A}$ is the area vector differential ($d\vec{A} = \hat{n} dA$ where $\hat{n}$ is the unit normal to S)
- Q_{enclosed} is the total charge **inside** the volume enclosed by S
- ϵ_0 is the permittivity of free space.

- The electric flux through any closed surface is proportional to the net charge enclosed within that surface.
- We can choose any closed surface we want (even imaginary ones) to take advantage of this law.

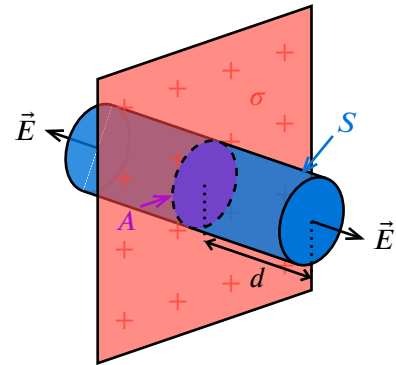
- A common strategy is to choose a Gaussian surface which takes advantage of symmetry to make calculating the electric field easier.
 - Where the electric field is perfectly perpendicular to our surface, then it is parallel to $\hat{n}$ and $\vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} = E dA$ (or $-E dA$ if the field points inwards).
 - Where the electric field is perfectly parallel to our surface, then it is perpendicular to $\hat{n}$ and $\vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} = 0$.

Example: Using Gauss' Law to find Electric Field

An infinite sheet of charge has a uniform surface charge density σ . Use Gauss' Law to derive an expression for the electric field a distance d from the sheet.

The first step is to choose the Gaussian surface.

- The electric field points directly away from the sheet on both sides
- We can choose a cylindrical surface where the electric field pierces through the two circular ends perpendicularly, and is parallel to the curved side of the cylinder. This way, we only have to consider the flux through the two circular ends of the cylinder.



Let the area of each circular end be A , and have the cylinder extend a distance d on either side of the sheet. We can then let the magnitude of electric field at each end be E .

Let's evaluate the left-hand side of Gauss' Law, the flux integral.

The electric field is parallel to the curved side of the cylinder, so they contribute no flux. At each circular end, the electric field is perpendicular to the surface, so the flux through each end is simply EA . Since there are two ends, the total flux is:

$$\Phi_E = EA + EA = 2EA.$$

For the right-hand side, the total charge enclosed by the cylinder is simply the charge on the portion of the sheet inside the cylinder. Since the sheet has a uniform surface charge density σ , the total charge enclosed is:

$$Q_{\text{enclosed}} = \sigma A.$$

Finally, applying Gauss' Law:

$$\begin{aligned}\Phi_E &= \frac{Q_{\text{enclosed}}}{\epsilon_0} \\ 2EA &= \frac{\sigma A}{\epsilon_0} \\ E &= \frac{\sigma}{2\epsilon_0}.\end{aligned}$$

Conductors in Electrostatic Equilibrium

- Remember that in a conductor, electrons are free to move
- If there is an electric field inside the conductor, electrons in the conductor will accelerate.

- For our conductor to be in **electrostatic equilibrium**, charges cannot be accelerating, or in other words there cannot be an electric field.
- Thus, *inside* a conductor at electrostatic equilibrium, $\vec{E} = \vec{0}$.
- By Gauss' Law extra charges in the conductor will be distributed to its surfaces.
 - Choose the Gaussian surface to be any surface completely within the conductor. Since there is no net electric field, there is no electric flux and since $\Phi_E \propto Q_{\text{enc}}$, $Q_{\text{enc}} = 0$.
- External charges can induce polarization on the conducting object, causing one side of the surface to have an opposite charge than the other side.

Introduction to Maxwell's Equations

Gauss' Law is typically the first equation introduced in the set of four equations fundamental to electromagnetism known as *Maxwell's Equations*:

Maxwell's Equations		
Name	Integral Form	Differential Form
Gauss' Law	$\oint_S \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} = \frac{Q_{\text{enclosed}}}{\epsilon_0}$	$\vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{E} = \frac{\rho}{\epsilon_0}$
Gauss' Law for Magnetism	$\oint_S \vec{B} \cdot d\vec{A} = 0$	$\vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{B} = 0$
Faraday's Law of Induction	$\oint_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = -\frac{d\Phi_B}{dt}$	$\vec{\nabla} \times \vec{E} = -\frac{\partial \vec{B}}{\partial t}$
Ampere-Maxwell Law	$\oint_C \vec{B} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = \mu_0 I_{\text{enclosed}} + \mu_0 \epsilon_0 \frac{d\Phi_E}{dt}$	$\vec{\nabla} \times \vec{B} = \mu_0 \vec{J} + \mu_0 \epsilon_0 \frac{\partial \vec{E}}{\partial t}$

Differential Form of Gauss' Law

Recall the Divergence Theorem:

$$\oint_S \vec{F} \cdot d\vec{A} = \iiint_V \vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{F} dV.$$

So, following Gauss' Law:

$$\begin{aligned} \oint_S \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{A} &= \iiint_V \vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{E} dV = \frac{Q}{\epsilon_0} \\ \frac{d}{dV} \iiint_V \vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{E} dV &= \frac{dQ}{dV} \frac{1}{\epsilon_0} \\ \vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{E} &= \frac{\rho}{\epsilon_0}. \end{aligned}$$

Gauss' Law (Differential Form)

The divergence of the electric field, $\vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{E}$, at any point is:

$$\vec{\nabla} \cdot \vec{E} = \frac{\rho}{\epsilon_0}$$

where ρ is volumetric charge density, charge per unit volume ($dq = \rho dV$).

2 Electric Potential

2.1 Electric Potential Energy

Let $\vec{F}_e$ be the electrostatic force on a charge q moving from point A to point B . The **electric potential energy** U_e is defined as the work done by an external agent to move the charge from A to B against the electrostatic force:

$$U_e = W_{\text{external}} = -W_{\text{electrostatic}} = - \int \vec{F}_e \cdot d\vec{\ell}.$$

If we assume q is only affected by one other point charge Q , we can substitute in Coulomb's Law:

$$U_e = - \int k_e \frac{qQ}{r^2} \hat{r} \cdot d\vec{\ell}.$$

Realize that $\hat{r}$ and $d\vec{\ell}$ are always in the same direction (since we are moving along the line between the two charges). Thus, we can let $dr = \hat{r} \cdot d\vec{\ell}$:

$$U_e = -k_e qQ \int \frac{1}{r^2} dr.$$

Solving the integral:

$$\begin{aligned} U_e &= -k_e qQ \left[-\frac{1}{r} \right]_{r_A}^{r_B} \\ &= k_e qQ \left(\frac{1}{r_A} - \frac{1}{r_B} \right). \end{aligned}$$

If we let final point be infinitely far away from point A ($r_B \rightarrow \infty$), then the electric potential energy at point A is:

$$U_e = k_e \frac{qQ}{r_A}.$$

Thus, we arrive at the general formula for electric potential energy between two point charges:

Electric Potential Energy from a Point Charge

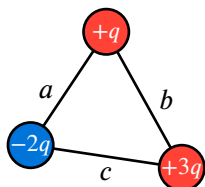
The electric potential energy of a point charge q a distance r from another point charge Q is:

$$U_e = k_e \frac{qQ}{r}.$$

This is the amount of work available to move the charge q from distance r to an infinite distance away from Q .

- Just like all forms of energy, electric potential energy is a *scalar quantity* and is measured in *Joules* (J).
- If both charges have the same sign, then U_e is positive, indicating that work wants to be done to separate the charges (they repel each other).
- If the charges have opposite signs, then U_e is negative, indicating that work is released when the charges come together (they attract each other).
- The reference point used for electric potential energy is that as $r \rightarrow \infty$, $U_e \rightarrow 0$.

Example: Electric Potential Energy of a Discrete System



A system of three point charges $+q$, $-2q$, and $+3q$ are arranged in a triangle with side lengths a , b , and c as shown. Calculate the total electric potential energy of the system.

The total potential energy in a system of discrete objects is the sum of potential energies between all pairs of objects.

Between $+q$ and $-2q$: $U_1 = k_e \frac{(+q)(-2q)}{a} = -2k_e \frac{q^2}{a}.$

Between $+q$ and $+3q$: $U_2 = k_e \frac{(+q)(+3q)}{b} = 3k_e \frac{q^2}{b}.$

Between $-2q$ and $+3q$: $U_3 = k_e \frac{(-2q)(+3q)}{c} = -6k_e \frac{q^2}{c}.$

Thus, the total electric potential energy of the system is:

$$U_e = U_1 + U_2 + U_3 = -2k_e \frac{q^2}{a} + 3k_e \frac{q^2}{b} - 6k_e \frac{q^2}{c} = k_e q^2 \left(-\frac{2}{a} + \frac{3}{b} - \frac{6}{c} \right).$$

Example: Electric Potential Energy of a Continuous System

A uniformly charged rod of length L and linear charge density λ lies along the x -axis from $x = 0$ to $x = L$. What is the electric potential energy of a point charge q located a distance d from the left end of the rod on the x -axis?



Since we are dealing with a continuous charge distribution, we use integration to find the total electric potential energy:

$$U_e = k_e q \int_{x=0}^{x=L} \frac{1}{r} dq$$

where r is the distance from the point charge to each small portion of charge on the rod.

Let x be how far from the left side of the rod we are (so we integrate from 0 to L). Then, $r = d + x$ and $dq = \lambda dx$:

$$U_e = k_e q \int_0^L \frac{1}{d + x} \lambda dx.$$

Since we know that the rod is *uniformly charged*, λ is constant, and we can now solve the integral and simplify:

$$\begin{aligned} U_e &= k_e q \lambda \int_0^L \frac{1}{d + x} dx \\ &= k_e q \lambda \ln(d + x) \Big|_{x=0}^{x=L} \\ &= k_e q \lambda (\ln(d + L) - \ln(d)) \\ &= k_e q \lambda \ln\left(\frac{d + L}{d}\right). \end{aligned}$$

Electric Potential Energy and Electrostatic Force

The electrostatic force is a **conservative force**. The work done by the force over a path only depends on the starting and ending positions, not the path taken.

The change in electric potential energy after following a path C is:

$$\Delta U_e = - \int_C \vec{F}_e \cdot d\vec{\ell}.$$

By the fundamental theorem of line integrals, we know that if a vector field $\vec{F}$ is the gradient of a scalar field f ($\vec{F} = \vec{\nabla} f$), then:

$$\int_C \vec{F} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = \int_C \vec{\nabla} f \cdot d\vec{\ell} = \Delta f.$$

This property only holds for conservative vector fields. Since the electrostatic force is conservative, we can apply this theorem:

$$\int_C \vec{\nabla} U_e \cdot d\vec{\ell} = \Delta U_e = \int_C -\vec{F}_e \cdot d\vec{\ell}.$$

Here, we see that $\vec{\nabla} U_e = -\vec{F}_e$. This is the general definition of electric potential energy:

Electric Potential Energy

The electrostatic force $\vec{F}_e$ on a charge is equal to the negative gradient of its **electric potential energy** U_e :

$$\vec{F}_e = -\vec{\nabla} U_e.$$

In one dimension, this simplifies to:

$$F_{e_x} = -\frac{dU_e}{dx}.$$

Things to Recall

- $W = -\Delta U$ ONLY if the work is done by a **conservative force**.
- $ME_i + W_{nc} = ME_f$ in an isolated system
 - The total energy in an isolated system is conserved, just like all other forms of energy:

$$\Delta E = \Delta U + \Delta K = 0 \implies \Delta K = -\Delta U.$$

- $ME_i + W_{ext} = ME_f$ in a non-isolated system

2.2 Electric Potential

Electric Potential from a Point Charge

Let q be a charge in an electric field $\vec{E}$. The electric potential energy U_e of the charge is:

$$U_e = qV$$

where V is the **electric potential** at the position of the charge.

- Electric potential is the electric potential energy per unit charge ($V = U_e/q$).
 - This is similar to how electric field is defined as force per unit charge.
 - Place a charge in a potential field. The potential “energizes” the charge.
- The unit of electric potential is the *volt* (V).
 - A volt is defined as one joule per coulomb ($V = J/C$).
 - An *electron-volt* (eV) is a unit of *energy*, which is the magnitude of potential energy of an electron in a 1 V potential: $1 \text{ eV} = (1.6 \cdot 10^{-19} \text{ C})(1 \text{ V}) = 1.6 \cdot 10^{-19} \text{ J}$.
- The electric potential V due to a point charge Q at a distance r is:

$$V = \frac{U_e}{q} = k_e \frac{Q}{r}.$$

This can be applied to the principle of superposition, where given a collection of point charges $\{q_i\}$,

$$V = k_e \sum_i \frac{q_i}{r_i}.$$

- Electric potential is a *scalar quantity*.
- Electric potential is often referred to as just “potential”.
- An **equipotential line** is a line along which the electric potential is constant.
 - Equipotential lines are always perpendicular to electric field lines (since $\vec{E} = -\vec{\nabla}V$).
 - Electric field lines flow from high potential to low potential
- Since $-\vec{\nabla}U_e = \vec{F}_e$, we can derive a relationship between electric potential and electric field:

$$\vec{F}_e = -\vec{\nabla}(qV) = -q\vec{\nabla}V \implies \vec{E} = \frac{\vec{F}_e}{q} = -\vec{\nabla}V.$$

Electric Field from Electric Potential

The electric field $\vec{E}$ at any point is equal to the negative gradient of the electric potential V at that point:

$$\vec{E} = -\vec{\nabla}V = \left\langle -\frac{\partial V}{\partial x}, -\frac{\partial V}{\partial y}, -\frac{\partial V}{\partial z} \right\rangle.$$

In one dimension, this simplifies to:

$$E_x = -\frac{dV}{dx}.$$

2.3 Potential Difference

- The **potential difference** ΔV between two points is the change in electric potential between them:

$$\Delta V = V_B - V_A.$$

From this, we can also derive the following relationship:

$$\Delta U_e = q\Delta V \implies \Delta V = \frac{\Delta U_e}{q}.$$

The potential difference between two points is the change in electric potential energy per unit charge between those two points.

- The electric field points in the direction of decreasing potential (simply because $\vec{E} = -\vec{\nabla}V$)

Since $\Delta U_e = -\int_C \vec{F}_e \cdot d\vec{\ell}$ and $\vec{F}_e = q\vec{E}$, we can write:

$$\begin{aligned}\Delta U_e &= -\int_C q\vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = -q \int_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} \\ \Delta V &= \frac{\Delta U_e}{q} = -\int_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell}.\end{aligned}$$

Potential Difference from Electric Field

The potential difference ΔV between two points is equal to the negative line integral of the electric field $\vec{E}$ along any path C between those two points:

$$\Delta V = -\int_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell}.$$

- Since $\vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = 0$ when $\vec{E}$ is perpendicular to the path, **equipotential lines are always perpendicular to the electric field**.
 - Similarly, the magnitude potential difference is maximized along the direction of the electric field (positive if against, negative if along).

Electric Potential with Conductors

- Recall that inside a conductor, there is zero net electric field: $\vec{E} = \vec{0}$. Thus, the potential difference between any two points *inside* a conductor is zero: $\Delta V = 0$.
- Since the electric field resides on the surface of a conductor, the electric potential *inside* a conductor is equal to the electric potential on its surface (no ΔV).

3 Conductors and Capacitors

3.1 Capacitors and Capacitance

- A **capacitor** $\text{--}||\text{--}$ is a device which “stores” electric charge, creating an electric field that results in a potential difference.
- A capacitor involves two separate conductors separated by an insulating material called a **dielectric**. Charges are allowed to move to the edges of each conductor, charging the ends, creating a potential difference.
- The **capacitance** is the maximum charge each conductor can hold per unit potential difference:

Capacitance

The **capacitance** C of a capacitor is defined as the ratio of the magnitude of charge Q on each conductor to the potential difference ΔV between them:

$$C = \frac{Q}{\Delta V}.$$

- The unit of capacitance is the *farad* (F), where $1 \text{ F} = 1 \text{ C/V}$.

Parallel Plate Capacitors

Two oppositely charged parallel plates a distance d apart create an approximately uniform electric field $\vec{E}$ between them. Let the surface charge densities of the two plates be $+\sigma$ and $-\sigma$, and let each plate have an area A .

Remember that the electric field from an infinite sheet of charge with surface charge density σ is $\frac{\sigma}{2\epsilon_0}$.

With two oppositely charged sheets, the electric field is double that: $E = \frac{\sigma}{\epsilon_0}$.

The potential difference ΔV between the two plates is:

$$\Delta V = - \int_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = -Ed = -\frac{\sigma d}{\epsilon_0}.$$

By the definition of capacitance:

$$C = \frac{Q}{\Delta V} = \frac{\sigma A}{\frac{\sigma d}{\epsilon_0}} = \epsilon_0 \frac{A}{d}.$$

Cylindrical Capacitors

In a cylindrical capacitor, the two conductors are coaxial cylinders with radii a and b ($a < b$) and length L . Note that the electric field between the cylinders is not uniform.

Remember that both conductors must carry the same charge Q , so we can assume they have the same linear charge density $\lambda = Q/L \rightarrow Q = \lambda L$.

Remember the electric field a distance r away from an infinitely long wire is $E(r) = \frac{\lambda}{2\pi r\epsilon_0}$. The potential difference between the inner and outer cylinders is:

$$\Delta V = - \int_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = - \int_a^b \frac{\lambda}{2\pi r\epsilon_0} dr = -\frac{\lambda}{2\pi\epsilon_0} \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right).$$

Finally, by the definition of capacitance:

$$C = \frac{Q}{|\Delta V|} = \frac{\lambda L}{\frac{\lambda}{2\pi\epsilon_0} \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)} = \frac{2\pi\epsilon_0 L}{\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)}.$$

Spherical Capacitors

In a spherical capacitor, the two conductors are concentric spheres with radii a and b ($a < b$). The electric field outside a sphere with charge Q is $E(r) = k_e \frac{Q}{r^2}$. The potential difference between the inner and outer spheres is:

$$\Delta V = - \int_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{\ell} = - \int_a^b k_e \frac{Q}{r^2} dr = -k_e Q \left(\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{b} \right).$$

By the definition of capacitance:

$$C = \frac{Q}{|\Delta V|} = \frac{Q}{k_e Q \left(\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{b} \right)} = \frac{4\pi\epsilon_0}{\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{b}}.$$

Energy of Capacitors

Capacitors store electric potential energy. Since charges want to move from one conductor to the other conductor in a capacitor, but can't, they have potential energy.

The **potential energy** stored by a capacitor is the work which can be done to move the charges from one conductor to another through the electric field between the conductors.

To find the potential energy, we can calculate the work done to charge the capacitor. Let Q be the final charge on each conductor, and let q be the charge at some intermediate point in the charging process. The potential difference at that point is $\Delta V = q/C$. The work done to move an infinitesimal amount of charge dq from one conductor to another is:

$$dW = \Delta V dq = \frac{q}{C} dq.$$

Integrating from 0 to Q :

$$W = \int_0^Q \frac{q}{C} dq = \frac{Q^2}{2C}.$$

Thus, the potential energy stored by a capacitor is:

$$U_C = \frac{Q^2}{2C}.$$

This can be rewritten as:

$$U_C = \frac{1}{2}Q\Delta V = \frac{1}{2}C(\Delta V)^2.$$

Energy Density

The **energy density** u is the amount of potential energy stored per unit volume:

$$u = \frac{U}{\text{volume}}.$$

For a parallel plate capacitor, the volume between the gap is Ad , so:

$$u = \frac{U_C}{Ad} = \frac{1}{2}C(\Delta V)^2 = \frac{1}{2}\frac{\epsilon_0 A}{d}(Ed)^2 = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon_0 E^2.$$

Realize that this formula no longer depends on any inherent property of the capacitor, *just* electric field. This means that it holds that *all* types of capacitors, not just parallel plate, have the same formula for energy density. In fact, the formula holds for *all* electric fields.

Example: Energy Density of a Spherical Capacitor

A spherical capacitor consists of two concentric spheres with radii a and b ($a < b$). A potential difference of ΔV is maintained between the two spheres. Derive an expression for the energy density u a distance r from the shared center of the spheres.

The energy density of the electric field is given by $u_e = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon_0 E^2$.

The electric field E a distance r from the center of the spheres is $E(r) = k_e \frac{Q}{r^2}$. We can find Q by using the potential difference between the two spheres:

$$\Delta V = k_e Q \left(\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{b} \right) \longrightarrow Q = \frac{\Delta V}{k_e \left(\frac{1}{a} - \frac{1}{b} \right)} = \frac{\Delta V ab}{k_e (a - b)}.$$

Substituting this into the formula for electric field:

$$E(r) = k_e \frac{Q}{r^2} = \cancel{k_e} \frac{\Delta V ab}{\cancel{k_e} (a - b) r^2} = \frac{\Delta V ab}{r^2 (a - b)}.$$

Finally, substituting this into the formula for energy density:

$$u(r) = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon_0 E^2(r) = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon_0 \left(\frac{\Delta V ab}{r^2 (a - b)} \right)^2 = \frac{\epsilon_0 (\Delta V)^2 a^2 b^2}{2r^4 (a - b)^2}.$$

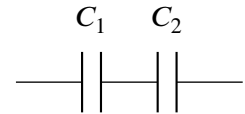
Capacitors in Series & Parallel

- When multiple capacitors are placed together in a circuit, their overall effects can be simplified into an **equivalent capacitor**. That is, we can treat groups of capacitors in a circuit as single capacitors.
- The two main arrangements (configurations) of capacitors are **series and parallel**.

Series

In **series**, the capacitors are connected end to end, so **each capacitor has the same charge Q** . However, the potential difference across each capacitor can be different.

Charge is the same on each capacitor due to conservation of charge.



The potential differences would add up to the equivalent potential difference:

$$\Delta V_{\text{eq}} = \Delta V_1 + \Delta V_2 + \dots + \Delta V_n.$$

By the definition of capacitance, $C = Q/\Delta V \rightarrow \Delta V = Q/C$. Substituting this into the sum of potential differences:

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta V_{\text{eq}} &= \frac{Q}{C_{\text{eq}}} = \frac{Q}{C_1} + \frac{Q}{C_2} + \dots + \frac{Q}{C_n} \\ \frac{1}{C_{\text{eq}}} &= \frac{1}{C_1} + \frac{1}{C_2} + \dots + \frac{1}{C_n}. \end{aligned}$$

Parallel

In **parallel**, the capacitors are connected such that **they all share the same potential difference ΔV** , but the charge on each capacitor can be different.

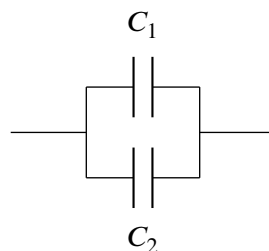
The charges would add up to the equivalent charge:

$$Q_{\text{eq}} = Q_1 + Q_2 + \dots + Q_n.$$

By the definition of capacitance, $C = Q/\Delta V \rightarrow Q = C\Delta V$. Substituting this into the sum of charges:

$$\begin{aligned} Q_{\text{eq}} &= C_{\text{eq}}\Delta V = C_1\Delta V + C_2\Delta V + \dots + C_n\Delta V \\ C_{\text{eq}} &= C_1 + C_2 + \dots + C_n. \end{aligned}$$

A parallel connection between C_1 and C_2 looks like the following:



3.2 Dielectrics

- A **dielectric** is an insulating material placed between the conducting plates of a capacitor to *increase* its capacitance.
- When a dielectric is placed in an electric field, it becomes polarized, meaning that the positive and negative charges within the dielectric are slightly separated.

This creates an induced electric field that *opposes* the original electric field, effectively reducing the potential difference between the plates.

Since potential difference is inversely proportional to capacitance, the capacitance increases.

- Let a capacitor with capacitance C_0 be without a dielectric. When a dielectric is added, the new capacitance is C . The ratio C/C_0 is called the **dielectric constant** of the material, denoted by κ :

$$C = \kappa C_0 \longrightarrow \kappa = \frac{C}{C_0}.$$

The dielectric constant represents the factor by which capacitance increases when the dielectric is added. For example, with a parallel plate capacitor, the new capacitance with a dielectric is:

$$C = \kappa \epsilon_0 \frac{A}{d}.$$

As mentioned, a dielectric really *decreases the potential difference*, so it can be more directly interpreted as the factor by which ΔV is decreased:

$$\Delta V = \frac{1}{\kappa} \Delta V_0.$$

- **Permittivity** is a measure of how easy it is for an electric field to polarize an insulating material.
 - The **permittivity of free space** or **vacuum permittivity** is ϵ_0 .
 - The term $\kappa \epsilon_0$ is referred to as the **absolute permittivity**, and is denoted with ϵ .
 - Accordingly, the scaling factor κ is sometimes called **relative permittivity** and denoted ϵ_r , such that $\epsilon = \epsilon_r \epsilon_0$.
 - When talking about conductors, the unit *farad per meter* (F/m) is often used to describe permittivity instead of $\text{N m}^2/\text{C}^2$. They are equivalent.

Partial Dielectrics

- A dielectric can partially fill a gap, or multiple types of dielectrics can fill a gap.
 - At the same time, dielectrics can fill gaps discretely or continuously.
- In the discrete case, we can simply treat partial dielectrics as conductors in parallel/series.

Electric Potential Energy in Dielectrics

- If U_0 is the energy stored by a capacitor with capacitance C_0 in a vacuum, then the energy stored by the same capacitor in a material with :

$$U = \frac{1}{2}C(\Delta V)^2 = \frac{1}{2}\kappa C_0(\Delta V)^2 = \kappa U_0.$$

- By the same logic, the energy density of an electric field in a dielectric is:

$$u = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon E^2 = \frac{1}{2}\kappa\epsilon_0 E^2 = \kappa u_0.$$

4 Electric Current and Circuits

4.1 Electric Current

Average and Instantaneous Electric Current

Let q be the amount of charge that passes through an arbitrary surface in a time interval Δt . The **average electric current** I_{avg} is:

$$I_{\text{avg}} = \frac{q}{\Delta t}.$$

The **instantaneous electric current** I is the time-derivative of flowing charge:

$$I = \frac{dq}{dt}.$$

- Electric current can be thought of as the rate of flow of *positive* electric charge.
 - But electrons are the charge carriers that actually moving, and they are negative. So, electric current is the *negative* rate of flow of electrons.
- Often, current is interpreted as the charge that moves through the cross section of a conductor, since charges can't really "flow" through nonconductors anyways.
- The SI unit of electric current is the *Ampere* (A, "amp"), where $1 \text{ A} = 1 \text{ C/s}$.
 - In fact, the Ampere is an SI *base unit*, and Coulombs are defined in terms of Amperes ($\text{C} = \text{A} \cdot \text{s}$).

Current Density

- The **current density** $\vec{J}$ describes the *electric current per unit area*: $J = I/A$.
- **Current density is a vector** which points in the direction of positive current flow.
- Combining these properties, we can roughly see that $\vec{J} = \frac{dI}{dA} \hat{v}$, where $\hat{v}$ is a unit vector in the direction of current flow. Formally:

Electric Current (Current Density Definition)

Let I be the electric current through a surface S . Then:

$$I = \iint_S \vec{J} \cdot d\vec{A}$$

where:

- $\vec{J}$ is the **current density** vector, which points in the direction of current flow and has magnitude equal to the current per unit area ($J = \frac{dI}{dA}$).
- $d\vec{A}$ is the area vector differential, which points perpendicular to the surface and has magnitude equal to the area of the differential element.

- Current density is measured in *amperes per square meter* (A/m^2).

Drift Velocity

- Each charge carrier (e.g. electron) has a certain **drift velocity** $\vec{v}_d$ which is the average velocity of the charge carriers in the direction of current flow. The current density can also be expressed as:

$$\vec{J} = nq\vec{v}_d$$

where n is the number of charge carriers per unit volume, and q is the charge of each carrier.

It can be interpreted that $\rho = nq$, where ρ is volumetric charge density. However, since charges are moving, we can only give an “average” charge carrier density which we call n .

- Drift velocities are often very small (on the order of 10^{-4} m/s), but the electric field that causes the drift propagates at nearly the speed of light, so the effect of turning on a current is almost instantaneous.
- The current density is proportional to drift velocity by a factor of nq .
- By the definition of current density, we can also express current as:

$$I = \iint_S \vec{J} \cdot d\vec{A} = \iint_S nq\vec{v}_d \cdot d\vec{A}.$$

In a wire, the current density is usually uniform across the cross-sectional area, and the drift velocity is parallel to the $d\vec{A}$ (i.e. we are taking a perpendicular cross section), so this simplifies to:

$$I = nqv_d A.$$

4.2 Electric Circuits

- An **electric circuit** is a closed loop of conductive material through which electric current can flow.
 - This conductive material is called a **wire** and along an isolated piece of wire, electric potential is constant (this makes sense because $\Delta V = 0$ inside a conductor)
- The **circuit elements** are the components of a circuit that affect the flow of current, such as resistors, capacitors, inductors, and voltage sources.
 - Circuit elements have the ability to create potential differences, and thus an electric field within wires to move charges.

Voltage Sources & Electromotive Force

- A **voltage source** is a circuit element that creates a potential difference ΔV between the two **terminals**. The side with the higher potential is usually referred to as the **positive terminal**, and the other end is called the **negative terminal**.
 - An example of a voltage source is a **battery** , which maintains the potential difference via a chemical reaction.
 - In a circuit diagram, the positive terminal of a voltage source is usually denoted by a longer line, while the negative terminal is denoted by a shorter line.
 - A battery may consist of multiple **cells** connected together, where each cell contributes a certain amount of potential difference. For example, a 9V battery may consist of six 1.5V cells connected in series. **Multicell batteries** are denoted by multiple pairs of lines, e.g. for two cells or for three cells.
 - By the conservation of charge, the same amount of charge pushed through one terminal must eventually return back on the other terminal.

Electromotive Force

The **electromotive force** (emf) $\mathcal{E}$ of a voltage source is the amount of work done by the source to move a unit charge from the negative terminal to the positive terminal:

$$\mathcal{E} = \frac{W}{q}.$$

It is the “ideal” potential difference that the voltage source would create if no current were flowing (i.e. if there was no internal resistance).

- The emf is a measure of the energy provided by the voltage source per unit charge.
- The emf of a voltage source is the voltage across the two terminals when *no current is flowing*.
 - When current flows, some energy is lost due to heat (**internal resistance**), meaning the actual effective potential difference across the terminals is less than the emf.
- Electromotive force is also measured in Volts (energy per unit charge)!

4.3 Ohm's Law and Resistors

- **Conductivity** σ is a measure of how easily electric current can flow through a material. The higher the conductivity, the easier it is for current to flow.
- The **resistivity** ρ is the reciprocal of conductivity ($\rho = 1/\sigma$) and is a measure of how much a material resists the flow of electric current.

Ohm's Law (Microscopic)

Let $\vec{J}$ be the current density through a material with conductivity σ , and let $\vec{E}$ be the electric field within that material. Then:

$$\vec{J} = \sigma \vec{E} \quad \longleftrightarrow \quad \vec{E} = \rho \vec{J}.$$

*The current density within a wire is proportional to the magnitude of the electric field by a factor σ called the **conductivity**.*

- Ohm's Law tells us that an electric field will drive current through a material, and more conductive materials will allow more current to flow per unit electric field.
 - Conversely, a material with higher resistivity will require a stronger electric field to drive the same amount of current.
- We can find the conductivity or resistivity of a material by comparing the current density and electric field within the material:

$$\sigma = \frac{J}{E} \quad \longleftrightarrow \quad \rho = \frac{E}{J}.$$

- Certain materials have a resistivity that changes with temperature. For example, the resistivity of a metal increases with temperature, while the resistivity of a semiconductor decreases with temperature.
 - Take a material with resistivity ρ_0 at some temperature T_0 . If the temperature changes to T and the new resistivity is ρ , then ρ follows the following relation:

$$\rho = \rho_0(1 + \alpha(T - T_0)).$$

We call α the **temperature coefficient of resistivity** of the material.

Resistance

From the equation $E = \rho J$, we can derive the concept of **resistance** R for a wire. Consider a wire with length L and cross-sectional area A . The current density is $J = I/A$, and the electric field is $E = \Delta V/L$. Substituting these into the equation:

$$\frac{\Delta V}{L} = \frac{\rho I}{A} \rightarrow \Delta V = \frac{\rho L}{A} I.$$

We can then define $R = \rho L/A$:

Resistance

The **resistance** R of a wire describes how much the wire resists the flow of electric current. It depends on the resistivity ρ of the wire's material, the wire's length L , and cross-sectional area A :

$$R = \frac{\rho L}{A} = \frac{L}{\sigma A}.$$

- That is, the longer wires have more resistance and thicker wires have less resistance.
- Substituting R back into the equation used to derive it, we get $\Delta V = RI$. This is another form of Ohm's Law, measuring the voltage required to drive a unit of current through the wire.

Ohm's Law (Macroscopic)

The current I flowing across a wire with voltage ΔV across it is given by **Ohm's Law**:

$$I = \frac{\Delta V}{R} \leftrightarrow \Delta V = IR \leftrightarrow R = \frac{\Delta V}{I}.$$

- The unit of resistance is the *ohm* (Ω), where $1\Omega = 1 \text{ V/A}$.
 - From this definition, we get the units for resistivity and conductivity: $\Omega \text{ m}$ and $\frac{1}{\Omega \text{ m}}$ respectively.
- **Conductance** G is the reciprocal of resistance ($G = 1/R$) and is a measure of how easily electric current can flow through a wire:

$$I = G\Delta V \leftrightarrow \Delta V = \frac{I}{G} \leftrightarrow G = \frac{I}{\Delta V}.$$

Internal Resistance & Terminal Voltage

- Batteries in real life have an **internal resistance** r . This means that the battery itself resists the flow of current, and thus the potential difference across the terminals is not equal to the emf $\mathcal{E}$ of the battery. The true potential difference across the terminals, called the **terminal voltage**, is:

$$\Delta V = V_{\text{terminal}} = \mathcal{E} - Ir.$$

- We can technically represent internal resistance by coupling together an ideal battery and a resistor with resistance r . The “fake” resistor is drawn on the side of the *positive* terminal.
- An **ideal battery** is one without internal resistance.

Note

While resistivity and conductivity are inherent properties of *materials*, resistance and conductance further depend on geometric properties of the wire.

For example, while the *resistivity* of copper is always the same, a long thin copper wire will have more *resistance* than a short thick copper wire.

Resistors

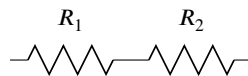
- A **resistor**  is a circuit element that has a specific resistance R and is used to control the flow of electric current in a circuit.
- Only *some* resistors obey Ohm's Law, meaning that current through the resistor increases linearly with supplied voltage (i.e. $I \propto \Delta V$, and we call the constant of proportionality the resistance R). In other words, the resistance is constant, no matter the voltage supplied.
 - A resistor that obeys Ohm's Law is an **ohmic** resistor. Otherwise, it is a **non-ohmic** resistor.
 - Non-ohmic resistors have a resistance that changes with the voltage across them. For example, a light bulb is a non-ohmic resistor because its filament heats up as current flows through it, which increases its resistance.
 - To check if a resistor is ohmic, check if $dV/dI = \text{some constant } R$.

Resistors in Series

Resistors placed in series have their potential differences add up, which means that:

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta V_{\text{eq}} = I R_{\text{eq}} &= \Delta V_1 + \Delta V_2 + \dots + \Delta V_n = I R_1 + I R_2 + \dots + I R_n \\ R_{\text{eq}} &= R_1 + R_2 + \dots + R_n. \end{aligned}$$

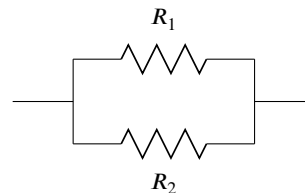
In series, resistors share the same current but have different potential differences.



Resistors in Parallel

Resistors placed in parallel have their currents add up but share the same potential difference, which means that:

$$\begin{aligned} I_{\text{eq}} &= I_1 + I_2 + \dots + I_n \\ \frac{\Delta V}{R_{\text{eq}}} &= \frac{\Delta V}{R_1} + \frac{\Delta V}{R_2} + \dots + \frac{\Delta V}{R_n} \\ \frac{1}{R_{\text{eq}}} &= \frac{1}{R_1} + \frac{1}{R_2} + \dots + \frac{1}{R_n}. \end{aligned}$$



In parallel, resistors share the same potential difference but have different currents.

4.4 Electric Power

- Recall that mechanical **power** P is the rate at which work is done: $P = dW/dt$.
- Electrical power** P_e is the rate at which electrical energy is transferred by an electric circuit:

$$P_e = \frac{dW_e}{dt} = -\frac{dU_e}{dt}.$$

- The electrical power delivered to a circuit element is the rate at which the element “absorbs” electrical energy, causing the element’s electric potential energy to decrease.
- We know that when charges move through a potential difference ΔV , they lose potential energy according to $\Delta U_e = q\Delta V$. In other words, the electric field does $-q\Delta V$ amount of work on the charges.

Thus, the power delivered to a circuit element is:

$$P_e = \frac{dW_e}{dt} = -\frac{dU_e}{dt} = \frac{d}{dt}(q\Delta V) = -I\Delta V.$$

- If a circuit element is *supplying* power, then the power is positive, so:

Electrical Power

The **electrical power** P_e supplied by a circuit element is given by:

$$P_e = I\Delta V.$$

Note that ΔV is the potential difference across the circuit element, **not** the emf!

- Using Ohm’s Law, we can also express power in terms of current and resistance:

$$\begin{aligned} P_e &= I\Delta V = I(IR) &&= I^2 R. \\ &= \left(\frac{\Delta V}{R}\right)\Delta V = \frac{(\Delta V)^2}{R}. \end{aligned}$$

4.5 Electrical Measuring Instruments

- An **ammeter** — A — is a tool used to measure a current at a specific point in a circuit.
 - Ammeters should be connected in series with the circuit element whose current we are measuring
 - Ideal ammeters have zero resistance (such that there is no current drop)
- A **voltmeter** — V — is a tool used to measure the potential difference between two points in a circuit.
 - Voltmeters should be connected in parallel with the circuit element across which we are measuring the potential difference.
 - Ideal voltmeters have infinite resistance (such that no current wants to flow through them)
- An **ohmmeter** — Ω — is a tool used to measure the resistance of a circuit element. It works by sending a small current through the element and measuring the potential difference across it, then using Ohm's Law to calculate the resistance.
 - Effectively, an ohmmeter is a combination of an ammeter and a voltmeter.

4.6 Kirchhoff's Rules

Kirchhoff's Loop Rule

Kirchhoff's Loop Rule is a statement about conservation of energy. Because the electric force is conservative, if a charge starts and ends at the same place in a circuit, it must have the same amount of mechanical energy: $\Delta U_e = 0$.

This means that the sum of the potential differences across all circuit elements in a *closed* loop is zero:

$$\sum_i \Delta V_i = 0.$$

This is simply an application of the FTC for line integrals:

$$\oint_C dV = - \oint_C \vec{E} \cdot d\vec{r} = - \oint_C \vec{\nabla} V \cdot d\vec{r} = V(\vec{r}) - V(\vec{r}) = 0.$$

In this case, it is important to keep track of the signs of ΔV_i . Sometimes, voltage *gains* (from emfs like batteries) are separated from voltage *drops* (from resistors and capacitors):

$$\sum_i \Delta V_i = \sum_i \Delta V_{\text{gain}} - \sum_i \Delta V_{\text{drop}} = 0 \rightarrow \sum_i \Delta V_{\text{gain}} = \sum_i \Delta V_{\text{drop}}.$$

The sum of all voltage gains is equal to the sum of all voltage drops.

Again, circuit components can cause either voltage gains or drops:

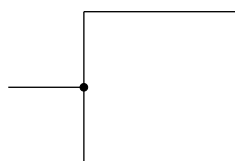
- Passing from the negative terminal to the positive terminal of a voltage source causes a voltage gain, while passing from the positive terminal to the negative terminal causes a voltage drop.
- Passing through a resistor or capacitor in the direction of current flow causes a voltage drop
 - If we pass through a resistor or capacitor *against* the direction of current flow, then it causes a voltage gain.

Kirchhoff's Junction Rule

Kirchhoff's Junction Rule is a statement about conservation of charge. The total current flowing into a junction must equal the total current flowing out of the junction:

$$\sum_i I_{\text{in}} = \sum_i I_{\text{out}}.$$

A **junction** is a point in a circuit where charges have the possibility of taking more than one path.



4.7 Resistor-Capacitor (RC) Circuits

Charging an RC Circuit

An **RC-circuit** is a circuit which is equivalent to one with a resistor and a capacitor.

Let's assume that before we close the circuit, the capacitor is uncharged. We can assign $q(t)$ to represent the charge on the capacitor, so $q(0) = 0$.

When we close the circuit, the battery will start pushing charge through the circuit, and the capacitor will start charging up. We call this **charging the capacitor**.

As the capacitor charges, it creates a voltage drop across itself, which reduces the current flowing through the circuit. Eventually, the capacitor will become fully charged and the current will stop flowing.

By Kirchhoff's Loop Rule, we can write an equation for the circuit:

$$\mathcal{E} - \Delta V_R - \Delta V_C = 0 \implies \mathcal{E} = \Delta V_R + \Delta V_C.$$

We closed the switch, so there should be some current $i = dq/dt$. The voltage drop across the resistor is $V_R = IR$, and the voltage drop across the capacitor is $V_C = q/C$. Substituting these into the equation, we get a first-order differential equation which allows us to solve for $q(t)$:

$$\mathcal{E} = iR + \frac{q}{C} \rightarrow \mathcal{E} = R \frac{dq}{dt} + \frac{1}{C}q \rightarrow q(t) = C\mathcal{E} \left(1 - e^{-\frac{t}{RC}} \right).$$

Similarly, we can find the current at any time t by taking the time derivative of $q(t)$:

$$i(t) = \frac{d}{dt}q(t) = \frac{\mathcal{E}}{R} e^{-\frac{t}{RC}}.$$

Since the potential difference across the capacitor is $\Delta V_C = q/C$, we can also find ΔV_C at any time t :

$$\Delta V_C(t) = \frac{q(t)}{C} = \mathcal{E} \left(1 - e^{-\frac{t}{RC}} \right).$$

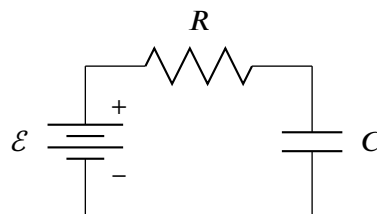
The quantity $\tau = RC$ is called the **RC time constant** of the circuit.

- After a time $t = \tau$, the charge on the capacitor will have reached about 63% of its final value, and the current will have dropped to about 37% of its initial value.
- Using the time constant, we can rewrite our equations:

$$q(t) = C\mathcal{E} \left(1 - e^{-t/\tau} \right) \quad i(t) = \frac{\mathcal{E}}{R} e^{-t/\tau} \quad \Delta V_C(t) = \mathcal{E} \left(1 - e^{-t/\tau} \right)$$

Note the following limits:

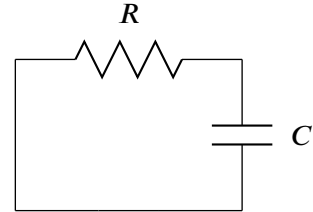
- $\lim_{t \rightarrow \infty} q(t) = C\mathcal{E}$: After a very long time, the capacitor approaches its maximum charge of $q_{\max} = C\mathcal{E}$.
- $i(0) = \mathcal{E}/R$ and $\lim_{t \rightarrow \infty} i(t) = 0$: The current starts at its maximum value of $i_{\max} = \mathcal{E}/R$ and eventually drops to zero.



- $\lim_{t \rightarrow \infty} \Delta V_C(t) = \mathcal{E}$: After a very long time, the voltage across the capacitor approaches its maximum value of $\Delta V_{C,\max} = \mathcal{E}$.

Discharging an RC Circuit

Now, let's assume that we have an RC-circuit with a fully charged capacitor, so $q(0) = q_0$. Then, the battery used to charge the capacitor is removed, and now the capacitor is allowed to discharge through the resistor. We call this **discharging the capacitor**.



By Kirchhoff's Loop Rule, we can write an equation for the circuit:

$$\Delta V_R + \Delta V_C = 0.$$

Substituting $\Delta V_R = IR$ and $\Delta V_C = q/C$ into the equation, we get:

$$R \frac{dq}{dt} + \frac{1}{C}q = 0 \rightarrow q(t) = q_0 e^{-\frac{t}{RC}}.$$

If we assume we started from a fully charged capacitor via emf $\mathcal{E}$, then $q_0 = C\mathcal{E}$, so we can rewrite as:

$$q(t) = C\mathcal{E} e^{-\frac{t}{RC}}.$$

Using $i = dq/dt$ and $\Delta V_C = q/C$, we can find the current and voltage across the capacitor at any time t :

$$i(t) = \frac{d}{dt}q(t) = -\frac{\mathcal{E}}{R} e^{-\frac{t}{RC}} \quad \Delta V_C(t) = \frac{q(t)}{C} = \mathcal{E} e^{-\frac{t}{RC}}.$$

Using the time constant $\tau = RC$, we can rewrite our equations:

$$q(t) = C\mathcal{E} e^{-t/\tau} \quad i(t) = -\frac{\mathcal{E}}{R} e^{-t/\tau} \quad \Delta V_C(t) = \mathcal{E} e^{-t/\tau}$$

Realize that:

- $\lim_{t \rightarrow \infty} q(t) = 0$: After a very long time, the capacitor will be fully discharged and have zero charge.
- $i_{\text{discharging}}(t) = -i_{\text{charging}}(t)$: The current during discharging is the same as the current during charging, but in the opposite direction. It still decays to zero over time.
- $\lim_{t \rightarrow \infty} \Delta V_C(t) = 0$: After a very long time, the voltage across the capacitor will drop to zero.

